**METRIC**

**A-A-20253A**
**May 8, 2008**
**SUPERSEDING**
**A-A-20253**
**September 4, 1997**

# COMMERCIAL ITEM DESCRIPTION

# CREAM CHEESE, NEUFCHÂTEL CHEESE, AND RELATED PRODUCTS

**The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) has authorized the use of this Commercial Item Description (CID).**

**1. SCOPE.** This CID covers Cream cheese, Neufchâtel cheese, and related products (Cream cheese), packed in commercially acceptable containers, suitable for use by the Federal, State, local governments, and other interested parties.

## 2. PURCHASER NOTES.

### 2.1 Purchasers *shall specify* the following:

- Type(s) and class(es) of Cream cheese desired (Sec. 3).
- When analytical requirements are different than specified (Sec. 6.1).
- When microbial requirements are different than specified (Sec. 6.2).
- When analytical requirements need to be verified (Sec. 6.2).
- Manufacturer's quality assurance or plant survey (Sec. 9.1), Manufacturer's/distributor's certification (Sec. 9.2) or USDA certification (Sec.9.3).

### 2.2 Purchasers *may specify* the following:

- Packaging requirements other than commercial (Sec. 10).

**3. CLASSIFICATION.** The Cream cheese shall conform to the following list which shall be specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

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**Types and classes.**

**Type I** - Cream cheese
- **Class A** - Cream cheese (21 CFR § 133.133)
- **Class B** - Reduced fat Cream cheese (21 CFR § 133.133, 21 CFR § 101.62, and 21 CFR § 130.10)
- **Class C** - Light/Lite Cream cheese (21 CFR § 133.133, 21 CFR § 101.62, and 21 CFR § 130.10)

**Type II** - Cream cheese with other foods (e.g., strawberries, chives, salmon, etc.) (*as specified by the purchaser)*
- **Class A** - Cream cheese with other foods (21 CFR § 133.134)
- **Class B** - Reduced fat Cream cheese with other foods (21 CFR § 133.133, 21 CFR § 133.134, 21 CFR § 101.62, and 21 CFR § 130.10)
- **Class C** - Light/Lite Cream cheese with other foods (21 CFR § 133.133, 21 CFR § 133.134, 21 CFR § 101.62, and 21 CFR § 130.10)

**Type III** - Neufchâtel cheese (21 CFR § 133.162)

**Type IV** - Neufchâtel cheese with other foods (e.g., strawberries, chives, salmon, etc.) (21 CFR § 133.162) (*as specified by the purchaser)*

**4. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S NOTES. Manufacturer's/distributor's products *shall meet* the requirements of the:**

- Salient characteristics (Sec 5).
- Analytical requirements: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 6).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's assurance (Sec. 7).
- Regulatory requirements (Sec. 8).
- Quality assurance provisions: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 9).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 10).

**5. SALIENT CHARACTERISTICS.**

**5.1 Processing.** The Cream cheese shall be pasteurized and processed in accordance with good manufacturing practices (21 CFR Part 110), (21 CFR § 133.133 for Cream cheese and 21 CFR § 133.134 for Cream cheese with other foods) and (21 CFR § 133.162 for Neufchâtel cheese and Neufchâtel cheese with other foods).

**5.2 Finished product.**



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**5.2.1 Cream cheese (Type I, Class A).** The Cream cheese shall comply with all applicable Federal regulations including those contained in 21 CFR § 133.133 for Cream cheese.

**5.2.2 Reduced fat and Light/Lite Cream cheese (Type I, Class B and Class C).** The Cream cheese shall comply with all applicable Federal regulations including those contained in 21 CFR § 133.133 for Cream cheese, 21 CFR § 101.62 for food nutrient content claims for fat, and 21 CFR § 130.10 for foods named by use of a nutrient content claim and a standardized term.

**5.2.3 Cream cheese with other foods (Type II, Class A).** The Cream cheese with other foods such as strawberries, chives, and salmon shall comply with all applicable Federal regulations including those contained in 21 CFR § 133.134.

**5.2.4 Reduced fat and Light/Lite Cream cheese with other foods (Type II, Class B and Class C).** The Cream cheese and related products with other foods such as strawberries, chives, and salmon shall comply with all applicable Federal regulations including those contained in 21 CFR § 133.134 for Cream cheese with other foods, 21 CFR § 101.62 for food nutrient content claims for fat, and 21 CFR § 130.10 for foods named by use of a nutrient content claim and a standardized term.

**5.2.5 Neufchâtel cheese (Type III) and Neufchâtel cheese with other foods (Type IV).** The Neufchâtel cheese and Neufchâtel cheese with other foods shall comply with all applicable Federal regulations including those contained in 21 CFR § 133.162. Neufchâtel cheese with other foods shall be labeled to identify any foods added.

**5.3 Dairy ingredients.** All dairy ingredients shall originate from plants approved by the Dairy Grading Branch (DGB), Dairy Programs (DP), Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS), USDA. All dairy products used as ingredients shall be free from all undesirable flavors and odors.

**5.4 Nondairy ingredients.**

**5.4.1 All stabilizers and emulsifiers.** These nondairy ingredients shall be clean and wholesome, and shall be established as safe and suitable by the Food and Drug Administration and comply with all regulations including the requirements in 21 CFR § 133.133 (b)(3)(iii), 21 CFR § 133.134 (b)(2)(i), and 21 CFR § 133.162 (b)(3)(iii).

**5.4.2 Food colors.** Food colors used in the manufacture of Cream cheese with other foods and Neufchâtel cheese with other foods shall be certified by the Food and Drug Administration as safe and suitable for human consumption. Cream cheese with other foods added shall meet the requirements in 21 CFR § 133.134 (b)(2)(ii). Neufchâtel cheese with other foods, if colored, shall be labeled as colored.



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**5.4.3 Salt.** Salt shall be free flowing, white, refined sodium chloride and shall meet the requirements of the Food Chemicals Codex.

**5.4.4 Added foods.** When other foods are added, they shall be clean, wholesome, and of uniform good quality; and shall be free from visible mold, rancid flavor, or decomposed particles. Such ingredients shall be consistent in size and color to produce the desired appearance and appeal of the finished product.

**5.5 Quality specifications.**

**5.5.1 Flavor.** The Cream cheese shall possess a slight lactic acid and cultured diacetyl flavor and aroma; no off flavors or odors such as bitter, flat, sulfide, and yeasty shall be present. When other food is added, it shall be added at a level sufficient to impart a desirable characteristic flavor to the finished product. The characterizing flavor shall not be at an intensity which results in a harsh or unnatural flavor.

**5.5.2 Body and texture.** The Cream cheeses shall be smooth, and free from lumps or grittiness. Reduced fat Cream cheese may be slightly weak or pasty. Light/Lite Cream cheese may be weak or pasty to a pronounced degree. Droplets or beads of moisture on the surface of the cheese are permissible. When labeled as “Soft”, the Cream cheese may contain less than 1 gram of moisture droplets that have run together or pooled. The Cream cheese shall not show evidence of cracking, serum separation, or wheying off. The Cream cheese shall be medium firm when cold 7.2°C (45°F), and be spreadable at room temperature 20°C (68°F). When labeled as “Soft”, the Cream cheese shall be spreadable at refrigeration temperature 7.2°C (45°F).

**5.5.3 Color and appearance.** The Cream cheese shall have a uniform white to light cream color. When other food is added, it shall be uniformly distributed and impart the desirable characteristic color to the finished product. The cheese shall be free from visible mold or other surface discolorations.

**5.6 Foreign material.** All ingredients shall be clean, sound, wholesome, and free from evidence of rodent or insect infestation.

**6. ANALYTICAL REQUIREMENTS.**

**6.1 Analytical requirements.** Unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the analytical requirements for the Cream cheese shall be as follows:



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**TABLE I. Cream cheese, Reduced fat, and Light/Lite Cream cheese, and Neufchâtel cheese:**

| Product | Percent moisture (Maximum) | Percent Milkfat (By weight of finished food) | pH | Percent salt (Maximum) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Cream cheese Type I, Class A | 55 | 33 percent (minimum) | 4.4 – 5.0 | 1.4 |
| Reduced fat Cream cheese Type I, Class B | 70 | Not less than 16.5 percent But less than 20 percent | 4.4 - 5.1 | 1.4 |
| Light/Lite Cream cheese Type I, Class C | 70 | Not more than 16.5 percent | 4.4 - 5.2 | 1.4 |
| Neufchâtel cheese Type III | 65 | Not less than 20 percent But less than 33 percent | 4.4 - 5.0 | 1.4 |

**TABLE II. Cream cheese with other foods, Reduced fat, and Light/Lite Cream cheese with other foods, and Neufchâtel cheese with other foods:**

| Product | Percent moisture (Maximum) | Percent Milkfat (By weight of finished food) | Percent salt (Maximum) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cream cheese with other foods Type II, Class A | 60 | Not less than 27 percent | 1.4 |
| Reduced fat Cream cheese with other foods Type II, Class B | 70 | Not less than 16.5 percent But less than 20 percent | 1.4 |
| Light/Lite Cream cheese with other foods Type II, Class C | 70 | Not more than 16.5 percent | 1.4 |
| Neufchâtel cheese with other foods Type IV | 70 | Not less than 20 percent But less than 33 percent | 1.4 |



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**6.2 Microbial requirements.** Microbial determinations shall be made in accordance with the methods described below in the Standard Methods for the Examination of Dairy Products. The Cream cheese shall not exceed the following values. Samples shall be taken as often as necessary to insure microbial control.

| | |
|---|---|
| Yeast | Less than 100 Colony Forming Units (CFU) per gram |
| Mold | Less than 100 CFU per gram |
| *Coliform* | Less than 10 CFU per gram or less than 3 MPN (Most Probable Number) per gram **1/** |
| *E. Coli* | Less than 10 CFU per gram or less than 3 MPN per gram **1/** |
| Standard Plate Count | Not more than 25,000 per gram |

**1/** Findings indicate zero colonies (CFU) per plate or zero tubes producing gas for MPN.

**6.3 Product verification.** When USDA verification of analytical requirements is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the following procedures will be followed.

**6.3.1 Sampling procedures.** USDA inspection service will select the number of product containers based on USDA, AMS, DP, DGB sampling procedures and plans.

**6.3.2 Composite sample.** Analytical testing shall be performed on a composite sample. The composite sample shall be 226.8 g (8 oz) and be prepared from subsamples drawn from randomly selected containers. The number of subsamples used to create the composite sample shall be based on USDA procedures.

**6.4 Analytical and microbial testing:** Analytical and microbial analysis shall be made in accordance with the following methods described in the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International, the Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM) method, or the latest edition of Standard Methods for the Examination of Dairy Products.

| **Test** | **Method** |
|---|---|
| Sample Preparation | 955.30 |
| Fat | 933.05, 922.06 |
| Moisture | 926.08, 977.11 |
| Salt | 983.14, 935.43 |
| pH | 15.024, 15.3 D **2/** |
| *Coliform* | 966.24, 2000.15, BAM Ch 4 **3/**, or 7.030 **2/** |
| *E. coli* | 966.24, BAM Ch 4 (IC & IF) **3/**, or 7.050 **2/** |
| Yeast and mold | 997.02, BAM Ch 18 **3/** or 8.110 **2/** |
| Standard Plate Count | 990.12, 966.23, BAM Ch 3 6.2 **3/**, or 6.020 **2/** |



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**2/** 8th Edition, Food and Drug Administration (FDA) Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM or the FDA BAM online.
**3/** Standard Methods for the Examination of Dairy Products, latest edition.

**6.5 Test results:** The test results for fat, moisture, and salt shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent. The test results for pH shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 value. The total standard plate count shall be reported to the nearest 10 per gram. The test results for yeast and mold shall be reported to the nearest 50 CFU per gram. The Test results for Coliform and *E.* coli shall be reported to the nearest 10 CFU per gram or to the nearest MPN per gram. Any test result not conforming to the analytical or microbial requirements shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

**7. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S PRODUCT ASSURANCE.** The manufacturer/ distributor shall certify that the Cream cheese provided shall meet the salient characteristics of this CID, conform to their own specifications, standards, and quality assurance practices, and be the same Cream cheese offered for sale in the commercial market. The purchaser reserves the right to require proof of conformance.

**8. REGULATORY REQUIREMENTS.** The delivered Cream cheese shall comply with all applicable Federal and State mandatory requirements and regulations relating to the preparation, packaging, labeling, storage, distribution, and sales of the Cream cheese in the commercial marketplace. Delivered Cream cheese shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act, the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act, and regulations promulgated thereunder. The delivered Cream cheese shall comply with the allergen labeling requirements of the Federal Food, Drug and Cosmetic Act.

**9. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS.** *Purchaser shall specify 9.1, 9.2 or 9.3.*

**9.1 Manufacturer's quality assurance and plant survey.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchaser order, the Cream cheese manufacturer shall be required to have their facilities inspected by USDA, Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS), Dairy Programs (DP), Dairy Grading Branch (DGB), and be eligible for listing in Section I of the AMS publication "Dairy Plants Surveyed and Approved for USDA Grading Service." *(An AMS plant survey verifies that, at the time of the survey, the manufacturer produces products in a clean, sanitary environment in accordance with Title 21 Code of Federal Regulations Part 110 - Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Packing, or Holding Human Food and the requirements contained in 7 CFR Part 58 General Specification for Dairy Plants Approved for USDA Inspection and Grading Service.)*

**9.2 Manufacturer's/distributor's certification.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the manufacturer/distributor will certify that the Cream cheese distributed meets or exceeds the requirements of this CID.



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**9.3 USDA certification.** When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order that product quality and acceptability or both be determined, the USDA, AMS, DP, DGB, shall be the certifying program. DGB inspectors shall certify the quality and acceptability of the Cream cheese in accordance with DGB procedures which include selecting random samples of the Cream cheese, evaluating the samples for conformance with the salient characteristics of this CID and other contractual requirements, and documenting the findings on official DGB certificates. In addition, when required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, DGB inspectors will examine the Cream cheese for conformance to the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers in effect on the date of the solicitation. To qualify for this option the plant must be listed in "Dairy Plants Surveyed and Approved for USDA Grading Service" (see Sec. 9.1).

**10. PACKAGING.** Preservation, packaging, packing, labeling, and case marking shall be commercial unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

**11. USDA INSPECTION NOTES. When Section 9.3 is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, USDA certification shall include evaluation of the quality and condition of samples of Cream cheese, and compliance with requirements in the following areas:**

- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical and microbial requirements *when specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order* (Sec. 6.1 and 6.2). When USDA analytical and microbial testing is specified, DGB inspection personnel shall select samples and submit them to the USDA, Science and Technology Programs (S&TP) laboratory for analysis.
- Packaging requirements (Sec. 10 or as specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order).

**12. REFERENCE NOTES.**

**12.1 USDA certification contact.** For USDA certification, contact the **Branch Chief, Dairy Grading Branch, DP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0230, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0230, telephone (202) 720-3171 or on the Internet at: www.ams.usda.gov/dairygrading/.**

**12.2 Analytical testing and technical information.** For USDA technical information on analytical testing, contact the **Branch Chief, Technical Service Branch, S&TP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0272, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0272, telephone (202) 690-0621, or via E-mail: shirleyj.wright@usda.gov.**

**12.3 Sources of documents.**



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**12.3.1 Sources of information for nongovernmental documents are as follows:**

Copies of the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International and the FDA Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM), either printed or on CD-ROM versions, may be obtained from: **AOAC International, 481 North Frederick Avenue, Suite 500, Gaithersburg, MD 20877, telephone (301) 924-7077. Internet address: http://www.aoac.org.**

Copies of the Food Chemicals Codex may be purchased from: **United States Pharmacopeial Convention, 12601 Twinbrook Parkway, Rockville, MD 20852-1790, telephone (800) 227-8772 or (301) 881-0666, Fax (301) 816-8148. Internet address: www.usp.org.**

**12.3.2 Sources of information for governmental documents are as follows:**

Applicable provisions of: the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act are contained in 16 CFR Parts 500 to 503 and the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act are contained in 21 CFR Parts 1 to 199. These documents may be purchased from: **Superintendent of Documents, New Orders, P.O. Box 371954, Pittsburgh, PA 15250-7954. Credit card (Visa, MasterCard, Discover/NOVUS, and American Express) purchases may be made by calling the Superintendent of Documents on (866) 512-1800, (202) 512-1800, or on the Internet at: http://www.gpoaccess.gov/nara/index.html.**

Copies of the FDA Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM) are available online from FDA, Center for Food Safety and Applied Nutrition **on the Internet at: http://vm.cfsan.fda.gov/~ebam/bam-toc.html.**

Copies of this CID, the United States Standards for Condition for Food Containers, and beneficial comments, recommendations, additions, deletions, clarifications, etc. and any data which may improve this CID are available from and/or provided to: **Branch Chief, PPB, FVP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0247, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0247, telephone (202) 720-9939, Fax (202) 690-0102, via E-mail: FQAStaff@usda.gov or on the Internet at: http://www.ams.usda.gov/fv/fvqual.hmt.**

Military activities should submit requests for copies of this CID to: **Standardization Documents Order Desk, Document Automation And Production Service, 700 Robbins Avenue, Building 4D, Philadelphia, PA 19111-5094 or on the Internet at: http://assist.daps.dla.mil/quicksearch/.**



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**MILITARY INTERESTS:**

**Military Coordinating Activity**

Army - GL

**Custodians**

Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 35

**Review Activities**

Army - MD, QM
Navy - MC
DLA - SS

**CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:**

DOJ - BOP
HHS - NIH, HIS, FDA
USDA - FV
VA - OSS

**PREPARING ACTIVITY:**

USDA - FV

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